

Chapter 108-1

Liang Wanwan was quite frozen, sneezing continuously on the way home, her voice sounding muffled as if she had caught a cold.

After Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu brought her back, although Xu Qingzhu was a little unhappy, she still left the space for the two sisters.

Xu Qingzhu went to the kitchen to make ginger sugar water for the two of them.

There was ginger at home, but Xu Qingzhu didn't know where the sugar was kept, so she could only ask Liang Shi.

But Liang Shi went to the kitchen instead and told her to go out and keep Liang Wanwan company.

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Liang Shi squeezed together with her in front of the small kitchen counter, their bodies brushing against each other. Liang Shi lowered her voice and said, "She's crying. I don't know how to comfort her."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

The look Xu Qingzhu gave her was also very straightforward—Do you think I would know how?

Their eyes met. Liang Shi said helplessly, "I think... you should be... a bit better at it than me?"

Liang Shi said this without much confidence either.

If she sat there, she'd probably only be good for handing over tissues.

And regarding the sketchbook from Chen Mian that Liang Wanwan mentioned, she didn't have that strong of an ability to empathize.

For Liang Wanwan, it was a very precious item, but when Liang Shi searched through the original owner's memories, it was nothing more than an ordinary sketchbook.

It was something Chen Mian had casually drawn as a favor to the original owner.

Liang Shi couldn't even figure out why the usually taciturn Chen Mian would do this favor for the original owner.

The original owner hadn't understood at the time either, but she had gladly accepted it.

Since Liang Shi didn't understand the significance of this sketchbook to Liang Wanwan, she naturally had no way to offer comfort.

She was also afraid of accidentally saying the wrong thing and making Liang Wanwan even more upset.

So Liang Shi chose to let the more "understanding" Xu Qingzhu go talk to her.

Xu Qingzhu stood there, her expression helpless. "Are you serious?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"Teacher Xu has always been so understanding." Liang Shi was now resolute. "Leave these small matters in the kitchen to me. Teacher Xu, please go take charge of the overall situation."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her, the corners of her eyes lifting slightly. She suddenly leaned close to her and repeated her words, "I'm understanding?"

Liang Shi nodded, looking quite obedient.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly reached out and pinched the side of her neck. The pain made Liang Shi inhale sharply, and the look she gave Xu Qingzhu was full of reproach, not knowing what she was doing.

But then Xu Qingzhu's hand moved downward. Her cool fingertips flicked at Liang Shi's collar, pulling down the originally somewhat high-necked sweatshirt collar. Xu Qingzhu's fingers landed on Liang Shi's collarbone.

Pressing down lightly.

This caught Liang Shi completely off guard, and her expression changed. She instantly felt as if her body was on fire, couldn't help but move closer to Xu Qingzhu, and even wanted to lean forward and embrace her.

Liang Shi's throat moved slightly as she swallowed.

Xu Qingzhu's cool voice sounded beside her ear. She scoffed softly with displeasure: "Not necessarily understanding of people's feelings, but I do have some talent for understanding people's clothes."¹

As she spoke, she leaned forward and bit directly onto Liang Shi's collarbone. Her other free hand landed on the back of Liang Shi's neck, her palm gathering her long hair tightly.

Liang Shi's hand fell onto her waist, subconsciously tightening.

But Xu Qingzhu quickly retreated. That bite seemed very much like venting frustration.

Yet Liang Shi had no idea where she had offended her.

But she had no chance to find out either. Xu Qingzhu had already left the kitchen gracefully, leaving behind a somewhat dazed Liang Shi and the faint teeth marks on her collarbone.

Liang Shi: "....."

Only after Xu Qingzhu left did she belatedly realize that phrase—"understanding people's clothes."

She had a feeling Xu Qingzhu was mocking her about this morning's incident.

Wasn't it just that she couldn't use her hands and feet together to perfectly get her pants off?

.....

Really now.

She even had to compete over this!

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1. This is a pun in Chinese. "善解人意" (shàn jiě rén yì) means "understanding/considerate of others' feelings." Xu Qingzhu changes it to "善解人衣" (shàn jiě rén yī), which sounds almost identical but means "good at removing people's clothes" (衣 meaning clothes). The pun implies Xu Qingzhu is teasing Liang Shi about her "talent" for undressing her, referencing an earlier intimate incident. ↩

Chapter 108-2

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Xu Qingzhu wasn't really much better than Liang Shi when it came to comforting people.

Especially when facing Liang Wanwan, whom she wasn't familiar with at all.

To her, Liang Wanwan was a stranger.

She had only met Liang Wanwan twice in total—once at her wedding to Liang Shi, and once when she went back to the old residence with Liang Shi.

Her impression of Liang Wanwan could be summed up in two words: quiet.

She and the former Liang Shi seemed like two extremes—one flitting among flowers and playing around in the world, the other being a quiet, well-behaved girl who had nothing to do with such matters.

So back then, everyone said that Qiu Zimin really knew how to raise children.

And Qiu Zimin knew precisely what all the moral standards were.

All her indulgence of Liang Shi was kept beneath the moral baseline.

She simply wanted to ruin Liang Shi, nothing more.

Xu Qingzhu was usually a rather quiet person herself. Now that she had been pushed out by Liang Shi to handle these matters, although she had no method to her approach, she could only steel herself and do it.

In front of Liang Wanwan, she could barely be considered an elder, so she initiated small talk: "Are you okay?"

Liang Wanwan first nodded, then slowly shook her head and called out aggrievedly, "Sister Qingzhu."

Liang Wanwan had a pure and innocent appearance. Without makeup, her fair face was full of collagen, and her eyes were red. She looked like a pitiful little white rabbit. Xu Qingzhu hurriedly handed her tissues and comforted her in a low voice: "Don't cry first. Your eyes are all red from crying."

Xu Qingzhu's only experience with comforting someone was with five-year-old Ling Dang.

In her family, Xu Qingya had an outgoing personality and had been carefree since childhood. And because she had been kidnapped when she was young, she had always stayed at home and never went out to school. From a young age, Xu Qingya had been taught to yield to her older sister and protect her.

Although she also wanted to be a good older sister, she never had the opportunity.

Xu Qingya was too strong, which only made her seem weak in comparison.

Besides, with Xu Qingya's personality, she didn't need comforting at all—you just needed to hand her tools when she wanted to go fight.

So when Xu Qingzhu was comforting Liang Wanwan now, it was a bit like coaxing a child, and even her voice unconsciously became more childlike.

Liang Wanwan was also immersed in her own world of sadness and didn't notice.

But Liang Shi, who was making ginger sugar water in the kitchen, heard it. She inexplicably rubbed her ears, the corners of her mouth curving upward.

Liang Shi tied up her hair with the hair tie she had taken from Xu Qingzhu's wrist. Misty steam drifted through the kitchen, and the small space was filled with the sweet smell of sugar.

Liang Shi thought it didn't smell as nice as the scent on Xu Qingzhu.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu was sitting in the living room feeling rather at ease.

She didn't feel like she absolutely had to do something just because Liang Wanwan was crying.

On the contrary, when Liang Wanwan cried, she just handed her tissues from the side and kicked the living room trash can over to Liang Wanwan's feet.

Liang Wanwan was usually accustomed to being quiet, so even her crying was very quiet.

It didn't make Xu Qingzhu feel troubled or emotionally drained.

When Liang Wanwan had cried until she was tired, until she had cried enough, she finally threw a large wad of tissues into the trash can. Then she let out a soft breath and said guiltily to Xu Qingzhu: "I'm sorry, Sister Qingzhu."

"It's nothing," Xu Qingzhu said. "Your sister went to make ginger sugar water. If you don't want to talk to me, you can wait for her to come out and then tell her."

It was like kicking the ball, passing this matter back to Liang Shi again.

But Liang Wanwan said, "That's not it. It's not that I don't want to talk to you."

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

"I... I just don't know how to say it." Liang Wanwan sniffled, wanting to cry again but forcibly holding it back. She apologized again: "I'm sorry for causing you trouble."

"It's not a big deal." Xu Qingzhu's tone was a bit like Sally's when she had just learned Mandarin—relaxed, trying to make Liang Wanwan not mind.

After a pause, Xu Qingzhu added: "This is your sister's home. If you've been wronged, just come here. Isn't that what older sisters are for?"

Liang Wanwan looked at her, her eyes glistening with tears.

Facing such a gaze from her, Xu Qingzhu felt quite pressured psychologically and flickered her eyes away.

Liang Wanwan thought for a moment before saying: "Sister Qingzhu, I'm a little scared."

"Scared of what?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Wanwan let out a heavy breath and was about to speak when Liang Shi walked out of the kitchen. She placed a cup filled with ginger sugar water in front of Liang Wanwan. There was even a purple straw in the cup—quite thoughtful.

Xu Qingzhu glanced over, and Liang Shi quickly brought over another cup, placing it in front of her.

Liang Shi said: "Drink the ginger sugar water first. Warm yourself up."

Liang Wanwan thanked her quietly, "Thank you, Jie."

Liang Shi went to the kitchen to put away the tray. Hearing her thanks, she said it was nothing.

After Liang Shi returned to the living room, Liang Wanwan finally talked about what happened that evening. Even after finishing, she was still so angry that her hands were shaking. "Why did she touch my clothes?! Even the servants at home don't touch them."

"Where did you put Chen Mian's sketchbook?" Liang Shi asked. "Is there any way to restore it?"

Liang Wanwan shook her head. "It's all soaked through. Completely ruined."

Water had seeped into the plastic-sealed packaging, getting everything wet. After going through the washing machine, it had almost all turned into shredded paper scraps. It was impossible to look at anymore.

However, Liang Wanwan had still kept it. She put it in her wallet.

Now she gently spread it out flat, but you couldn't tell what it had originally looked like at all.

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Seeing Liang Wanwan treat the sketchbook on that sticky note so carefully, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu exchanged a glance and saw helplessness in each other's eyes.

This was something that simply couldn't be restored.

However, seeing how sad Liang Wanwan was, Liang Shi tentatively said: "How about I contact Chen Mian again and have her draw you another one?"

She had expected Liang Wanwan to agree without hesitation, but Liang Wanwan shook her head. "No, thank you."

She refused so quickly that Liang Shi thought she had misheard.

She couldn't help but confirm: "What?"

"There's no need." Liang Wanwan said: "Even if I got another one, it wouldn't have any meaning."

It was this sketchbook that had accompanied her through her youth, and also through those difficult days when she was preparing for the art college entrance exam.

And many sleepless nights spent missing Chen Mian.

Now that this sketchbook was gone, it also meant her youth should come to an end.

This secret crush should draw to a close.

Originally, she had intended to end this silent crush, which was why she had asked Liang Shi to request this favor from Chen Mian.

But what she got in return was an even longer attachment and a deeper bond.

Liang Wanwan lowered her eyes, her voice sorrowful. "Thank you, Jie."

She gazed at the sketchbook that was now unrecognizable, let out a deep breath, and said to Liang Shi: "Jie, I've disturbed you tonight. I'll just stay here for one day and go back to school tomorrow. You don't need to worry about me."

"Then what are you afraid of?" Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked her. "You still haven't talked about what you mentioned earlier."

When Liang Wanwan heard this question, her body stiffened for a moment. She said quietly: "Forget it."

"How can we just forget it?" Liang Shi frowned. "You slapped Liang Xinran—haven't you received any phone calls?"

"Yes." Liang Wanwan pressed her lips together and looked up at Liang Shi. "I have two phone numbers. I turned off one of them."

The other number was from a SIM card issued by the school for connecting to the dormitory network. Qiu Zimin didn't know about it.

Fear and timidity were still evident in Liang Wanwan's eyes.

Looking at her, Liang Shi suddenly understood a phrase—timid yet defiant.¹

The seemingly most inconspicuous Liang Wanwan was the first person in that family to slap Liang Xinran.

Although she was afraid of Qiu Zimin, she had still secretly gotten two phone numbers while appearing compliant on the surface.

Liang Shi thought for a moment. "Have you thought about what to do afterward?"

Liang Wanwan bit her lip. "I'll go back to school. Mom can't possibly come make a scene at our school, right? Besides, we're going to another province next week. If she can't find me, she won't do anything... right?"

Liang Wanwan was soft-hearted after all. After pausing for a moment, she said: "I don't know if what I did was right or wrong either. Mom feels especially guilty toward her, and she seems to have good intentions too. It's like she got scared after driving away Da-ge and Er-ge, so she's trying to please me, but..."

Liang Shi listened quietly as she spoke.

Liang Wanwan held the cup of ginger sugar water that was still steaming, her palms wrapped around the cup for warmth. She murmured softly: "I just can't bring myself to like her."

Liang Shi asked: "Why?"

Liang Wanwan took a sip of water. The hot water traveled from her mouth through her throat and all the way to her stomach, and she felt warmth throughout her entire body.

After a long while, she slowly said: "I feel like she's always acting weak, but her weakness has hurt a lot of people. I only found out after I came home that Er-ge had also moved out, and Mom is bedridden. The whole family feels so exhausted. What I did seems like..."

"There's no 'seems like.'" Liang Shi said: "Your feelings are probably right."

Liang Shi didn't say too much more. She just let her go check Liang Xinran's Weibo herself.

The original ID was still "Girl Searching for Family Guo Xinran," but it had now been changed to @Liang Xinran.

The bio read: Thank you to everyone. I have returned to my biological parents' side.

Her pinned post had also been changed to a long list of thank-you messages.

Probably for the traffic, she hadn't deleted any of her original Weibo posts. You could see all the content by clicking into them.

After reading through it, Liang Wanwan was puzzled: "She has so many followers. How could she have no money? Based on the level of follower monetization, her monthly income should be at least ten thousand yuan."

"Exactly." Liang Shi said: "And the content of her Weibo posts is so meticulous that it doesn't seem like she wrote them herself at all."

Liang Wanwan's fingers swiped across the screen a few times. "I didn't know what her background was. I actually wanted to get along with her normally."

For Liang Wanwan, getting along normally just meant occasionally having a few meals together. Since she was preparing her graduate school application for studying abroad and would probably spend the next several years overseas, she didn't really care who came to live in the family home.

After all, she was just an invisible person in that house anyway.

But she never expected that this person had only been there for a week and had already turned the whole family upside down.

Liang Wanwan looked at her previously pinned Weibo post. The more she looked at it, the more familiar the writing style seemed.

She switched the app to WeChat and searched for a public account.

This was one her roommate had recommended she follow before, calling it "million-view copywriting" and "rhythm master."² Her roommates were all people who loved eating melons,³ always at the forefront of internet surfing, while she tended to be a beat slower than everyone else.

Because she had really liked Yang Shuyan for a while, she had followed this public account under her roommates' guidance, since it had published several articles related to Yang Shuyan.

After opening it, Liang Wanwan casually clicked on an article about some celebrity in the entertainment industry.

This person had a formatting habit—they particularly liked using enumeration commas,⁴ and also liked using "的" (de) and "了" (le).⁵

These two characters appeared especially frequently in their articles, often showing up in places where they weren't necessary. It would seem somewhat abrupt, yet it didn't affect readability. After reading more, you would even feel that their writing was smooth and fluent.

1. "又慫又剛" (yòu sǒng yòu gāng) literally means "both cowardly and tough"—describing someone who appears timid but actually has a stubborn, defiant side. ⇐
2. "節奏大師" (rhythm master) in Chinese internet slang refers to someone who is skilled at manipulating public opinion or "controlling the narrative/rhythm" of online discussions, often by writing viral content that stirs up controversy. ⇐
3. "吃瓜" (chī guā, literally "eating melons") is Chinese internet slang for watching drama unfold or being a spectator to gossip, similar to "watching the tea" or enjoying drama from the sidelines. ⇐
4. The enumeration comma "、" (dùn hào) is a punctuation mark unique to Chinese used to separate items in a list, similar to how commas separate list items in English. ⇐
5. "的" (de) and "了" (le) are extremely common grammatical particles in Chinese. "的" is a possessive/attributive particle, while "了" indicates completed action or change of state. Overusing them is a distinctive writing quirk that can make text identifiable. ⇐

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Liang Wanwan handed the article to Liang Shi to look at. "Jie, does this look like it was written by the same person?"

Liang Shi skimmed through it quickly, then passed it to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu quickly noticed the same word usage habits and incorrect punctuation usage.

"This person... is no simple character." Xu Qingzhu said.

"They're very expensive." Liang Wanwan said. "They wrote an article about Yang Shuyan before that got over a million views. Just that one article alone earned over three hundred thousand yuan."

So the question arose—why was Liang Xinran able to hire this person?

Was she really poor?

Or had all her money gone into marketing?

Would someone who understood marketing this well act as fragile as she did at the Liang family home?

Of course not.

Even someone as slow as Liang Wanwan understood now.

"Is she faking it?" Liang Wanwan asked. "Why would she do this? What good does it do her to squeeze all of us out of the Liang family?"

"The family business." Xu Qingzhu reminded this naive little sister from the side.

Liang Wanwan paused. "Mom and Dad were already planning to draft a will early for her sake, afraid we'd swallow up her share."

So she didn't quite understand why Liang Xinran was stirring up so much trouble.

"Perhaps it's not about getting her rightful share, but about wanting to take everything for herself?" Xu Qingzhu said. "Sometimes you can't just look at the surface."

Liang Wanwan: "....."

She asked in surprise: "No way?"

Liang Shi was also more inclined toward this answer and chimed in: "Nothing's impossible."

"But she doesn't know anything about business operations. Squeezing me out doesn't matter, but if she squeezes out Da-ge and Er-ge, who's going to manage the company?" Liang Wanwan said. "Dad is already swamped as it is."

Liang Shi didn't know the answer to this question either and turned her gaze toward Xu Qingzhu, who understood these things.

Xu Qingzhu said in a deep voice: "She could hand these matters over to people who know what they're doing. But isn't she worried about being sidelined?"

Xu Qingzhu also found her a bit hard to understand.

After chatting for a while, they finally managed to pull Liang Wanwan out of her bad mood somewhat.

Then Liang Shi received a call from Liang Xinzhou, asking if she had seen Liang Wanwan. Liang Shi started a video call, and Liang Wanwan timidly greeted Liang Xinzhou.

Liang Xinzhou had originally wanted to say something, but seeing her eyes red from crying, he swallowed all his words of reproach and changed them to: "Rest well at your sister's place. Don't run around."

Liang Wanwan nodded. "Okay."

Then Liang Xinzhou turned and asked Liang Shi: "Can you look into Xu Tong's father?"

Liang Shi: "Huh? What's going on?"

Liang Xinzhou said: "His company before last was Haiwei Jewelry. He was fired on suspicion of leaking company secrets. Then he worked at another company for a month before being laid off. Have Xu Qingzhu ask Haiwei Jewelry about what exactly he leaked. I have a feeling she's connected to Liang Xinran."

Liang Shi was shocked. "That man? Doesn't his wife know?"

Liang Xinzhou said: "She probably doesn't."

Liang Shi didn't know what clues Liang Xinzhou had actually found. She glanced at Xu Qingzhu, and Xu Qingzhu nodded at her, indicating her agreement before Liang Shi accepted.

After hanging up, she discussed this matter with Xu Qingzhu. Both of them felt it was absurd.

But in the end, Xu Qingzhu summarized it with one sentence: Dogs that bite don't bark.¹

Liang Shi: "....."

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That night, Liang Wanwan slept in the guest bedroom, while Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi once again slept in the same room.

This day had been full of ups and downs. Liang Shi felt exhausted. As for sleeping in the same bed as Xu Qingzhu—the first time was unfamiliar, but the second time felt natural.

The bed sheets had just been changed at noon today. The old sheets were still in the laundry basket, unwashed. The washing machine had been occupied with their clothes, and after hanging them up it was already late. The two had rushed out, so there hadn't been time to wash the sheets.

When Liang Shi finished washing up and walked into the room, she felt as if the romantic atmosphere from that morning hadn't yet dissipated.

She got onto the bed and sat on one side. On the other side was Xu Qingzhu, who was reading a book.

Xu Qingzhu was reading a poetry collection, still entirely in English.

Liang Shi lay down, gazing at her from the side. The dim yellow light illuminated Xu Qingzhu, making her look especially radiant.

This scene was warm and cozy, perfect for a pictorial shoot. Liang Shi watched, completely mesmerized.

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu turned a page. The sound of pages rustling echoed in the room. Liang Shi's hand was pillowed under her head. Her sleeve had gotten a bit wet from washing up earlier, but it didn't matter much.

Xu Qingzhu unconsciously murmured a line in English, which could be heard fairly clearly in the quiet room.

Her English pronunciation was very pleasant to listen to, like the kind you'd often hear in foreign films.

A thought stirred in Liang Shi's heart, and she suddenly said: "Xu Qingzhu, read me a poem."

She rarely made requests of Xu Qingzhu, especially one this direct.

Because today Xu Qingzhu had told her: Liang Shi, you should be yourself.

So tonight, Liang Shi was trying to take the first step.

Xu Qingzhu's hand, which had been about to turn the page, paused. She lowered her eyes to look at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi was full of anticipation, her light brown eyes filled with warmth. Xu Qingzhu's fingertips traced along the bottom of the page.

A cool voice sounded in the room: "Teacher Liang, are you using me to complete your KPI again?"²

Liang Shi: "....."

1. "會咬人的狗不叫" (huì yǎo rén de gǒu bù jiào) is a Chinese saying meaning "dogs that bite don't bark"—implying that truly dangerous people don't show their intentions openly or make threats; they act quietly and unexpectedly. ⇐
2. KPI stands for Key Performance Indicator, a business term for measurable targets used to evaluate success. Xu Qingzhu is sarcastically suggesting that Liang Shi is only making this request to fulfill some kind of task or quota (referring to the system tasks that Liang Shi has been completing). ⇐